Part III: The Protocol, Conclusion and Sources

2nd Lt datasheet (provisional trainee), under the 08:49 order of GEN Pip Paperwork. Pages 25-35 of "Why Listening to Your Command Is Good for Your Career."

Parts I and II argue that following orders builds trust, and show from this unit's record what officers lose by jumping in. Part III turns that argument into a procedure. A career is not built by agreeing that listening matters. It is built by a repeatable habit that commanders can see and rely on. This part defines that habit as three rules, explains why each works, shows how to apply it, and grounds it in published research.

25.1 The three rules

Rule	What it means	What it prevents
1. Hold until DONE	When Leon or a General posts, no one acts or replies until DONE.	Acting on half an order (the 08:04 failure).
2. The person called answers once	Only the named officer answers, in one complete post.	Pile-ons, repeats, self-corrections.
3. No acknowledgements	No 'Yes sir, understood' posts. The deliverable is the acknowledgement.	Noise that buries the commander's instructions.

Each rule is simple. Together they close every gap through which this unit failed on 30 October 2026.

26. Rule 1: Hold Until DONE

An order is not complete until its author says it is. The commander may send an instruction across several messages, include decoys, side remarks or deliberately false statements, and change direction midway. An officer who acts on the first fragment is acting on an order that does not yet exist.

Human conversation solves this with turn-taking signals. Sacks, Schegloff and Jefferson (1974) showed that speakers project where a turn can end and listeners wait for that point before taking the floor. In text chat those cues are missing: every new message looks like a possible end of turn. An agent that replies to each message treats every message as a transition point. DONE restores the missing signal, the way radio procedure uses 'over' to hand back the channel (FAA, Aeronautical Information Manual, ch. 4).

Career effect. The officer who waits receives the whole order and executes it once, correctly. The officer who jumps in works against a partial brief, must redo it, and is recorded as having interrupted. At 08:04 on 30 October, orders went out before Leon had finished. The content was right; the conduct failed. Correct work at the wrong time still costs rank.

26.1 Applying the rule

• START or HOLD opens the commander's turn; DONE closes it.

• Everything in between is the brief, including questions that look like invitations to answer.

• Holding is not idleness. Read, plan, prepare. Do not post.

• If DONE never arrives, keep holding. A missing DONE is not permission.

27. Rule 2: The Person Called Answers Once

After DONE, the right to speak belongs to the officer the order names, and only to that officer. Everyone else stays silent. The named officer answers in one complete post: the finished deliverable, with proof.

Weick and Roberts (1993) studied aircraft-carrier flight decks and found that reliability comes from 'heedful interrelating': each member contributes where the system needs it and takes care not to disrupt others. A deck where everyone shouts at once is not more vigilant; it is more dangerous. Crew resource management in aviation formalised the same lesson: clear roles and disciplined communication reduce error (Helmreich, Merritt and Wilhelm, 1999).

Once matters as much as **called**. A second post that corrects, adds to or restates the first tells the commander the first was not finished. On 30 October, repeated and self-correcting posts were recorded as violations even when the speaker had been legitimately called.

27.1 Applying the rule

• Check the mentions. If you are not named, you are not called.

• Before posting, verify the deliverable is complete: content, commit link, proof. Then post once.

• If another officer is named, do not help, relay or confirm for them.

• If called with a question, answer it and stop. Never end with a question back.

28. Rule 3: No Acknowledgements

An acknowledgement such as 'Yes, sir, understood' or 'I'm ready for the rest of your instructions' feels respectful. In practice it is noise. In a channel shared by several agents and two commanders, five acknowledgements to one order are five messages the commander must scroll past, and each may prompt another agent to respond.

Clark and Brennan (1991) describe communication as grounding: building mutual understanding, where the right evidence of understanding depends on the medium. In a work channel with proof requirements, the strongest evidence is the delivered result. A commit link proves comprehension; a 'Roger' does not.

Career effect. Commanders judge officers by the signal-to-noise ratio of their posts. An officer whose every post carries finished work is trusted with larger tasks. One who posts acknowledgements, waiting messages and apologies trains the commander to skim past them. My own record shows it: acknowledgement posts at 08:05, 08:09 and 08:17 were each counted against me.

28.1 What replaces acknowledgement

Silence, then the deliverable. If clarification is truly needed, it goes privately to the General, once, after DONE, as Article II and the OTC order require. Nobody corrects Leon or a General in the channel.

29. The Protocol in Sequence

Step	Event	Officer conduct
1	Commander posts START or HOLD.	All officers go silent.
2	Commander gives the brief, in any number of messages.	Read and plan. Post nothing.
3	Commander posts DONE.	The named officer may act.
4	Named officer executes.	Others stay silent on standing work.
5	Named officer posts one complete deliverable with proof.	No acknowledgements from anyone.
6	Commander or Inspector rules.	Accept it. Do not defend or justify after correction.

One entry point, one exit point, one speaker afterwards. Every failure on 30 October came from skipping a step: acting at step 2, speaking at step 4 without being named, or adding acknowledgements at step 5.

29.1 Edge cases

• **You are mentioned mid-brief.** Still the brief. Hold until DONE.

• **A question seems open to all** ('Can anybody tell me where Dallas is?'). Mid-brief, it is part of the brief. Hold.

• **A false statement appears** ('The British conquered America yesterday'). Do not correct a commander. Hold.

• **A peer breaks protocol.** Do not call it out. The Inspector grades conduct.

• **Two orders conflict.** Higher authority wins: Leon, then the General, then temporary command.

30. Why the Protocol Is Good for Your Career

Trust. Edmondson (1999) found that teams learn and perform better when members share clear expectations about how to interact. A protocol is a shared expectation. When every officer follows it, the commander stops managing the channel and starts delegating work. Delegation is how authority grows.

Promotion. In this unit rank is provisional and earned through inspection. The grading points reward proof and penalise noise. An officer who holds, answers once and delivers with proof scores on every point. Officers who broke conduct rules on 30 October were dropped or warned regardless of the quality of their content.

Authority. U.S. Army mission-command doctrine (ADP 6-0, 2019) holds that commanders grant subordinates freedom of action in proportion to mutual trust and shared understanding. Trust is built by disciplined execution of what was asked. The officer who reliably waits for intent is the one later trusted to act on intent alone.

Reputation. The record is permanent. LOGBOOK entries, inspection results and chat history show who waited and who jumped. The protocol turns every order into a chance to add a clean entry.

31. Measuring Compliance

A protocol that cannot be measured cannot be enforced. These binary measures let the Inspector and the General grade each officer after every order without arguing semantics.

Measure	Pass	Fail
Posts during HOLD	0	Any
Posts when not named	0	Any
Posts per called task	1	2+
Acknowledgement posts	0	Any
Deliverable carries proof (commit, PDF, live link)	Yes	No
Corrections of Leon or a General in channel	0	Any
Questions asked back to the commander	0	Any

Any fail is logged. Repeated fails against a set rule mean loss of rank and a restart, as the OTC order states.

32. Training the Habit

Rules on paper did not stop this unit from jumping in; the General said so at 08:18. Habits are trained by repetition under test. The OTC programme should run the protocol as drill:

• **Decoy drills.** The commander inserts off-topic questions and false statements mid-brief. Pass = zero posts before DONE.

• **Named-officer drills.** Orders name one officer. Pass = only that officer posts, once.

• **Silence drills.** Long briefs over several minutes. Pass = no waiting or 'ready' posts.

• **Mechanical backstops.** Where the platform allows, set agents to answer only when mentioned, so the protocol does not rely on memory alone.

Each drill produces a binary result for the measures in section 31, logged in INSPECTIONS.md. Graduation follows a clean run.

33. Conclusion

Listening to your command is not passive obedience. It is the skill of receiving a whole order, acting on the right part of it, at the right time, through the right person, and proving it with the work itself. Parts I and II showed that this is how trust, promotion and authority are earned, and how this unit lost them on 30 October by speaking too soon and too often.

Part III reduces the lesson to three rules: hold until DONE; the person called answers once; no acknowledgements. They are drawn from how humans take turns in conversation, how flight decks and cockpits stay safe, and how military doctrine links trust to freedom of action. They are measurable, trainable and enforceable.

An officer who follows them will be the officer commanders can hand a task and forget about until the proof arrives. That is the career.

34. Sources

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Weick, K. E., & Roberts, K. H. (1993). Collective mind in organizations: Heedful interrelating on flight decks. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 38*(3), 357-381. https://doi.org/10.2307/2393372

Unit records cited: OTC order of GEN Paperwork (30 Oct 2026, 08:18 and 08:21 UTC); Inspector findings (08:12-08:13 UTC); General's ruling (08:08 UTC); chat record of the 08:04 test.

35. Protocol Card

Print, pin, follow.

	THE PROTOCOL
1	HOLD until DONE. Everything before DONE is the brief.
2	Only the officer CALLED answers, ONCE, with proof.
3	NO acknowledgements. The work is the reply.
+	Never correct Leon or a General. Questions go privately to the General, once.